

[SEC-OPS-2026-05] [Critical Windows persistence correlation detected - Unauthorized access](#) Created: 13/Mar/26 Updated: 14/Mar/26 Resolved: 13/Mar/26

Status:	Done
Project:	SEC-OPS
Components:	SIEM (Wazuh), Endpoint Security, Windows, Sysmon
Affects versions:	None
Fix versions:	None

Type:	Incident	Priority:	Highest
Reporter:	Sai Prasad	Assignee:	Sai Prasad
Resolution:	True Positive	Votes:	0
Labels:	credential-compromise, persistence, powershell, scheduled-task, ssh, sysmon, true-positive,		
Remaining Estimate:	0h		
Time Spent:	50m		
Original estimate:	2h		

Attachments:	
Rank:	0 i0004v:

Description

On March 13, 2026 at 11:26 IST, Wazuh SIEM triggered Rule 600999 for user `sp` on Agent2-windows-10 (192.168.29.80). The correlation rule detected PowerShell execution, hidden file creation in `.syslogs` directory, and scheduled task creation within 300 seconds.

Key Findings:

- Attacker gained initial access via OpenSSH using compromised credentials from source IP **192.168.29.50** at 11:20:45

- Reconnaissance commands executed: whoami, ipconfig, netstat, powershell - ExecutionPolicy Bypass
- Malicious script `health_monitor.ps1` deployed in hidden directory monitoring Notepad.exe activity
- Persistence established via scheduled task "NotepadMonitor" running at logon
- NO DATA EXFILTRATION - Script lacks exfiltration capability, zero outbound connections detected

Actions Taken:

- Endpoint isolated within 3 minutes
- User account disabled immediately
- Scheduled task deleted, hidden directory removed
- Password reset enforced, account re-enabled
- Full system reboot confirmed clean

Verdict: True Positive - Fully Remediated

Impact: Low (No data loss, no lateral movement)

Closure: 50 minutes from detection

Comments

Comment by [Sai Prasad](#) [13/Mar/26]

SSH authentication analysis complete. Attacker accessed endpoint at 11:20:45 from source IP 192.168.29.50 (confirmed via OpenSSH logs). User had legitimate sessions at 10:17-10:37 from same IP, indicating credentials were compromised after 10:37. Isolating endpoint immediately.

Comment by [Sai Prasad](#) [13/Mar/26]

Endpoint Agent2-windows-10 isolated via Windows Firewall. Added rules to block all inbound and outbound traffic. User account sp disabled. IT Operations notified. Incident declared Level 3 (Active Persistence)

Comment by [Sai Prasad](#) [13/Mar/26]

Discovery phase reconstruction complete using Sysmon logs. Attacker executed whoami, ipconfig, netstat, and powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass within 70 seconds of access at 11:21. Standard reconnaissance pattern observed.

Comment by [Sai Prasad](#) [13/Mar/26]

Malicious script recovered from C:\Users\sp\AppData\Local.syslogs\health_monitor.ps1. Script masquerades as "Health Monitoring System" but tracks Notepad.exe process creation and termination every 2 seconds, logging timestamps to health_monitoring.log. SHA256: B086A540AF33E14A543416057AC1ACB5D72E3A27249CAFE62D9FB7FEAE2A28F6. No exfiltration functionality present.

Comment by [Sai Prasad](#) [13/Mar/26]

Collected data log analysis complete. Script executed at 11:23:16 via scheduled task. One Notepad session captured (opened 11:22:55, closed 11:23:01). Minimal data collected before isolation. No exfiltration occurred.

Comment by [Sai Prasad](#) [13/Mar/26]

Scheduled task "NotepadMonitor" identified. Task created, runs at logon with 10-second delay, executes hidden PowerShell script. Last executed at 11:25:36. Primary persistence mechanism confirmed.

Comment by [Sai Prasad](#) [13/Mar/26]

Full system persistence sweep complete. Only one persistence mechanism detected: scheduled task "NotepadMonitor". All other locations (Startup, Registry, WMI, Services) are clean. No backup or redundant persistence present.

Comment by [Sai Prasad](#) [13/Mar/26]

Lateral movement check complete. No network logons to other systems, no explicit credential usage to remote systems, no administrative share access, no remote PowerShell sessions. All 4648 events are localhost only (normal system activity). Incident contained to single endpoint.

Comment by [Sai Prasad](#) [13/Mar/26]

NO DATA EXFILTRATION OCCURRED. Security logs show zero outbound connections during compromise window. Sysmon logs confirm no network connections. Malicious script contains no exfiltration functionality. Minimal data collected before isolation. Successful containment

Comment by [Sai Prasad](#) [13/Mar/26]

Eradication complete. Scheduled task "NotepadMonitor" deleted. Hidden directory. syslogs and all contents removed. PowerShell processes terminated. Alternate data streams checked and preserved in evidence.

Comment by [Sai Prasad](#) [13/Mar/26]

User account remediated. Password reset enforced, account re-enabled. IT Operations coordinating with user to ensure new password meets complexity requirements.

Comment by [Sai Prasad](#) [13/Mar/26]

Isolation firewall rules removed. Endpoint restored to production. User confirmed normal access and connectivity.

Comment by [Sai Prasad](#) [13/Mar/26]

A full system reboot was performed to confirm successful remediation. Verification results show the scheduled task did not reappear, the hidden directory remains permanently removed, and there are no residual or suspicious PowerShell processes. The task scheduler is confirmed clean, showing only legitimate entries (FamilySafetyMonitor and MsCtfMonitor). The endpoint is now verified as secure.

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